

What is waiting on a decision, and what is waiting on a document

Prepared 7 September 2026 by the Lunenburg Budget Project, an independent archive of the town and school budgets at lunenburgbudgetproject.org.
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The Lunenburg Budget Project — for review, 7 September 2026

4 decisions and **13 open questions**. The gap registry behind the questions holds **37 rows** across 5 kinds: `document_wanted`, `held`, `money_in`, `money_out`, `people`.

The two lists are kept apart because they behave differently, and section 3 below is the part worth reading first if you read nothing else.

1. Decisions waiting on TJ

Not questions about the data — questions about what this project should do. Nothing below is blocked on more analysis; each is blocked on somebody choosing.

#	THE DECISION	WHY IT IS YOURS AND NOT MINE	COST OF LEAVING IT
~~D1~~	~~ Push the database to D1. ~~ DONE 7 Sep 2026 — 70,013 rows in one pass; D1 verified to match the local copy, 78 tables. The plan's "140,026 writes" warning proved pessimistic: the ceiling is not rows x 2, and what exhausted the budget on 5 September was four re-imports in one day rather than the size of one.		
~~D2~~	~~ Deploy. ~~ DONE 7 Sep 2026 — v11 is live, verified against the archive manifest.		
D3	Resume the tax-rate and town-meeting extraction, or drop it. Held after repeated <code>ECONNRESET</code> . Your instruction was to hold if the agents keep failing and continue if some make progress.	The balance-sheet and special-revenue extractions since then both succeeded, so the evidence has changed.	Two datasets stay uncaptured. Nothing else depends on them.
~~D4~~	~~ What to do about athletics.md being stale. ~~ DONE 7 Sep 2026 — both analyses corrected, the page no longer disagrees, and the verifier now reads both documents and recomputes the series it had never checked.		
~~D5~~	~~ Extract the FY2024/FY2025 enterprise-only combining balance sheets. ~~ DONE 7 Sep 2026 — both years tie to their own printed PROOF; FY2024's two printings agree figure for figure. Found a \$102,000 pair of compensating errors and a published query that had never been run.		
~~D6~~	~~ The PEG revenue-vs-expenses statements. ~~ DONE 7 Sep 2026 — eleven editions, not ten: FY2023's statement and both FY2024 tables were catalogued as absent and are not. All tie. The FY2019 town meeting article settles the rename as a reorganisation, which makes <code>Starting Balance</code> mean different things either side of it. Four published figures for the fund on 30 June 2025 and nothing joins any pair.		
D7	Send a records request. The gaps registry now names specific documents rather than describing absences — the FY2023 trial balance, the five athletics memos, the <code>Account_Detail</code> export for orgs S3066672/S3066671, DESE's End of Year Financial Report. That is a letter, not a list.	It is outbound, to the Town, in your name.	The gaps stay gaps. Several are load-bearing.
~~D8~~	~~ Audit the other extracts for the parenthesised-negative defect. ~~ DONE 7 Sep 2026 — reduced from eighteen investigations to four, because an extractor that ties to a printed control total cannot hide a sign error. One latent defect found and guarded (<code>extract_grants.py</code> would silently DROP a negative rather than flip it); <code>check_money_parsers.py</code> registered.		

D10	Whether to re-derive the model's 2% state-aid rate. It is recorded as <code>BARE</code> — no stated source, no derivation — and measured Chapter 70 receipts grew 4.47%/yr FY2014–FY2022. The two are not comparable (different quantity, different span, actual-to-actual vs forward), so this is not a bug report; it is a question about whether to go and build the comparable series.	Changing a projection rate moves every published figure downstream of it, and rule 14 says a correction that size makes <i>other</i> errors findable. That is a decision with a workload attached.	The rate stays unsupported, and the site keeps saying so honestly. Not urgent.
~~D11~~	~~ Fix <code>source_ref</code> in <code>extract_free_cash.py</code> .~~ DONE 7 Sep 2026 — <code>source_ref</code> now names the amount's own cell and a new <code>label_ref</code> names the label. The extractor re-opens the workbook and asserts every one of the 630 citations resolves to its own figure before it writes; proved it refuses by breaking the column arithmetic by one. The free-cash page's workaround is deleted.		
D9	Whether <code>held</code> is the right fourth side in the gaps registry, alongside <code>money_in</code> , <code>money_out</code> , <code>people</code> and <code>document_wanted</code> . Added for the balance-sheet gap: money the town is holding is genuinely neither in nor out.	A taxonomy is an editorial choice and it renders on a public page.	Nothing breaks. Sides are read off the data, so changing it is a CSV edit.

2. Open questions — the data ones

These do not resolve by choosing. Each needs a document, and each names the one that would close it. All are registered in `sources/data/money-gaps.csv` unless marked.

Load-bearing, in the sense that other conclusions rest on them:

1. **Which fund pays which post.** The in-district special education escalator is built on a paraprofessional line, and that line cannot be distinguished from grant money unwinding. This is the single most consequential unknown in the project. *Closes:* DESE's End of Year Financial Report, which separates spending by fund.
2. **Whether a general fund athletics line is net of the revolving fund.** Rule 11's problem at its sharpest, on the one programme where both sides are visible. *Closes:* the MUNIS `Account_Detail` export for orgs S3066672 and S3066671.

Specific and probably closeable:

1. **What the \$87,293.86 is.** Two tables in the FY2023 annual report state the same quantity and differ. Not a misreading — the page ties to itself in all six columns. The `Sale of Cemetery Lots` explanation is tested and dead (§4 above). *Closes:* the Town's FY2023 trial balance as of 30 June 2023.

2. **The residual \$14.23** inside that. No FY2023 fund carries it, positive or negative. Probably not independently meaningful, but it is unexplained and unexplained is the honest word.
3. **Whether the \$87,293.86 is connected to the \$17,861.24** the town restated in grant funds between the FY2022 and FY2023 reports. Two different amounts in the same year. *Nothing joins them* — that is a statement about the evidence, not a denial.
4. **What the four GEN journal entries moved.** \$254,121.18 into fund 1301 in FY2025, two thirds of the year's inflow, described in the ledger only as *per memo*. *Closes*: the five memos.
5. **FY26 year-end.** Everything held for FY26 stops at 31 March.
6. **What any Cherry Sheet actually says.** We hold none, for any year — every aid figure in this project is read off a ledger, a proof workbook or a DESE file rather than off the document that states the aid. *Closes*: DLS forms CS 1-ER and CS 1-EB for Lunenburg, FY2021–FY2027.
7. **Whether an aid shortfall lands on the schools or on the town.** FY2024 came in \$390,814 under estimate. Who absorbed it is in nothing we hold. *Closes*: the fiscal-year-end recap (Form A-1), beside the Cherry Sheet.
8. **How many children Chapter 70 is paid for.** Foundation enrolment is 1,599; DESE's own measures give 1,563, 1,568.9 and 1,665.9. Four counts of four different things. *Closes*: DESE's FY27 foundation enrolment worksheet.

Bounded rather than answerable:

1. **How many children play sports.** Two town documents give 593 and 649 for the same year and count different things. No unduplicated count is published.
2. **Whether the fee rises moved participation.** Fees +30%, participations –3.9%, over exactly the same years. This is not a data gap that a document closes — it is a causal question the data cannot carry, and I do not expect it ever to. Listed so that nobody re-opens it thinking a records request would settle it.
3. **Whether a large CL#11 is prudence, a hiring freeze, a slipped project or an over-budgeted line.** Relevant to the free cash page in progress; the components do not distinguish them.

3. How to use the two lists

The distinction is the whole point of keeping them apart. **\$6 items go stale** — a decision not taken is a decision taken by default, and D1/D2 in particular decay into "the site is out of date and nobody chose that". **\$7 items do not go stale.** They are correctly parked, they are published on */what-we-cannot-answer*, and the honest state of a \$7 item is open.

The failure mode to avoid is treating a \$7 item as if it were a \$6 one — deciding what the \$87,293.86 probably is, rather than asking for the trial balance. Rule 7 exists because that conversion happens quietly and reads like

progress.

Extracted from `notes/findings/DRILL-IN-PAGES.md` sections 6-8 by `scripts/build_decisions_doc.py`. The counts above are computed at build time, and the gap count is read from `sources/data/money-gaps.csv` — so if a question here is not registered there, these two numbers stop agreeing.